

End-User Knowledge Initiative

How might we embed the end-user into the decision-making process at every level of [Company]?

Problem Statements

Business

As the market grows and adapts to technological changes new customer end-users need to be identified and understood, as well as how they vary for global to SMB customers. The business needs to know how best to communicate to these personas as it relates to the buyers as well as the users of the [Company] product suite.

Product

As our product becomes more modular and decentralized the end-user will no longer be a trained product expert. Our new product end-users will be diverse, ranging in technical skillset, and conduct a variety of workflows to achieve their responsibilities. Therefore our product needs to be held accountable to this information so that adoption and value for these end-users increase.

Knowledge Gathering

The first step in meeting the above outcome is to establish a fundamental and inclusive framework that continually gathers this ever-changing information so that it can pollinate and grow to be a part of the [Company] discourse.

Building Ethos

This knowledge cannot be owned by a single individual, department, or process. To ensure pollination the information must be continually requested, gathered, shared, and applied.

Glossary

Archetype / Persona

Are representations of audience clusters, capturing major areas of overlap in user behaviors, attitudes, motivations, pain points, and goals. *(Note that these clusters are not based on either demographic characteristics such as age, country, income, or personality traits such as extraversion and openness.)*

By finding these clusters of users, a small set of composites showcase key characteristics and major differences across a few types of users.

Workflows

Depictions of what the end-user does in their normal day-to-day work. These are key to identifying and operating as a base layer for other elements such as pain points, objectives, and user flows.

User flows

Lays out the user's movement through the product, mapping out each and every step the user takes—from entry point right through to the final interaction. (*Note the difference between workflows and user flows*)

Product narrative

A scenario writing, or story, that places a persona into a realistic situation that provides empathy to the reader. It includes clear user actions, is outcome-oriented, and describes pain points or obstacles in the personas day to day activity.

Advisory Team

- Executive representative
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- Product lead representative
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- Revenue representative
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- Customer representative
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- Design representative
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Action Team

- Design representative
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- Research representative
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- Product representative
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Knowledge Share

To ensure that the discourse of our users permeates product conversations, regardless of level, there must be continuous knowledge sharing; the least of which is a readout. Structural measures need to be in place so that each Aktanian has access to this information; usable information as well as actionable. The most important element of this structure is accountability; answering the question “who is this for” any time our product is being discussed, presented, or debated.

Key artifacts

- Formalized PDF of insights to a list of defined archetypes
 - Product end-user archetypes
 - Marketing archetypes

Resources

[Company] Product Archetype wiki

Cliff notes for effective end-user evidence gathering

Product brief template

Foundational Work

Evidence gathering

The action team will:

- Review and codify the raw interview notes collected during Vision demo reviews which were conducted last year
 - This information will then be used to identify potential product archetypes, illustrate gaps in the known knowledge of these archetypes, and be used to draft an interview guide which will be used to acquire additional information
- Review and codify the RFPs [Company] has submitted for over the past year
 - This information will then be used to provide insights as to product needs and market shifts
 - This information will also be used to inform the archetype interview guides

Advisory team will:

- Comprise a prioritized list of desired personas to be researched
 - This list should be broken down into two prioritizations
 - Product end users
 - Marketing/Sales
 - This list should also include how this information will be used and recommendations on how best to disseminate it across teams

Institutionalized practices

The value of this information comes from how it is used throughout the company; practices that should grow, be held accountable and can be used as a pillar of fact. The end result is that the [Company] product discourse is centralized around the identified and defined “persona”.

- Product Team
 - All product briefs will include which archetype is being addressed and those official PDFs will be attached if available.
 - Specific archetypes are called out on the Lean Product Canvas.
- Scrum Team
 - Roadmaps will include archetypes being addressed with every release review, prioritization, and release retro. So that the objectives of the release move beyond what a team can “commit” in said number of sprints, to what problems are being solved for said “persona”.
- Product Marketing collateral
 - Will include archetype problems and end-user product solutions being delivered with each release.
- Leadership decks
 - When presenting product strategy via a formalized deck a dedicated slide capturing the known archetype is to be included to help ground the viewers as to who this application is for; prior to going into conceptual solutioning. It is also advised as best practices to attach each used archetypes PDF to the deck's appendix.

These above approaches are a limited few, but act as a starting point for growth, in getting evidence-based user information institutionalized in how each [Company] employee thinks about our product and their individual efforts to deliver our product.

The Need

The relationship between product strategy, data gathering, and real-world understanding of our end-users remains weirdly tenuous. Without a directive, "poor quality research" informs or fails to inform, product/business/market discourse. Often starts with a disconnect between strategy and inquiry; *i.e. it's only safe to ask the questions that support a given strategic direction*. As a result, this narrows the focus towards irrelevant questions or extracts results based on using the most readily available data sources. Providing skewed and/or useless end-user learnings.

The goal **IS NOT** the production of new knowledge. The goal is to foster a learning culture at [Company] in order to make increasingly well-informed business decisions, decrease risk, and increase the chance of success in the midst of continuously changing business conditions.